

PLSC 476: Empirical Legal Studies

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Political Science Horizons

The **Political Science Horizons Mentoring Program** is a one-year long program sponsored by the Political Science department. The program hosts a series of events and provides opportunities that give students valuable social, academic and career related information and skills. The program also awards one student a paid one-month research assistantship with a faculty member in PLSC. Our goal is to support student academic success and teach students about the various career paths available to Political Science majors.

We encourage all first year Penn State students with a strong interest in Political Science and 1st-3rd year Political Science majors to apply to the program. First generation students, students of color, veterans and students belonging to the LGBTQ+ community are especially encouraged to apply. We do not ask for GPAs but match students based on need. More information on the program can be found at the program website: <https://sites.psu.edu/psuhorizons/>.

We are now recruiting for the 2025-2026 cohort. We will accept 20 students into the program. **The application deadline is September 26**, and acceptance decisions will be announced September 29. The application can be downloaded from the application page on the program website. Completed applications should be sent to the program faculty advisor Professor Vineeta Yadav, at vyadav@psu.edu.

Inherent and Operational Goals

14 The Puzzle of Judicial Behavior

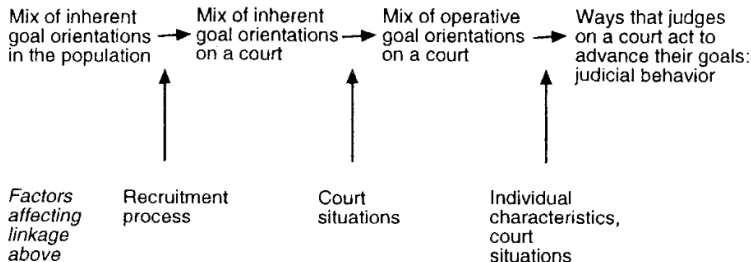


Fig. 1.1. A framework for analysis of judicial behavior. (Terminology is explained in the text.)

A Goal Typology

TABLE 1.1. A Partial Typology of Possible Goals for Judges

- I. *Content of Legal Policy*
 - Accurate interpretation of the law ("legal accuracy")
 - Clear and consistent interpretation of the law ("legal clarity")
 - Good policy as gauged by the judge's policy preferences ("good policy")
 - II. *Personal Standing with Court Audiences*
 - Popularity and respect in the legal community
 - Popularity and respect in the community as a whole
 - Power outside the court
 - III. *Career*
 - Continued tenure in the current judicial position
 - Promotion to a higher court
 - Securing attractive nonjudicial positions
 - IV. *Life on the Court*
 - Good relations with other judges and with participants in the courts who have other positions
 - Power within the court
 - Limited work loads
 - Court resources
 - V. *Standard of Living*
 - Personal income
 - Personal comfort
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